



between colonists who arrived there in the 15th century and African slaves. The word “creole” originally referred to anyone of European parentage born in the New World. Now, of its several different meanings,

the most common, spelled Créole, refers to the people of this heritage who live in the French West Indies (such as St. Lucia, Martinique, Guadeloupe, Dominica, and Haiti), and whose colorful culture reflects their dramatic past.

CRÉOLE SOUNDS

Music is an integral part of Créole culture, and many local rhythms have become popular worldwide: zouk and beguine from Martinique and Guadeloupe, for example, and meringué from Haiti and Dominica. Another dominant musical style is American jazz, as interpreted with a strong Caribbean flavor by this small but enthusiastic band in Guadeloupe.



Exotic blooms that grow wild in the Caribbean provide this young girl with all the carnival finery she needs.



TABLE TOURNAMENT

Créole men take their dominoes seriously and often play for money. Here, intense concentration shows on the faces of both competitors and observers at an outdoor match in St. Lucia.



SEDUCTIVE LANDSCAPES

The islands of the West Indies are actually the tops of underwater—often volcanic—mountains. Because of this, the landscape of each one consists of central hills or highlands that slope down to lush coastal plains ending in white sandy beaches. These attract visitors from all over the world, and the resulting tourism is one of the two most important industries in the region; the other is farming.

SPRINGTIME CELEBRATIONS

Virtually every Créole island supports its own colorful carnival involving parades, street parties, costumes, masks, dancing, and feasting. Although preparations begin in January, the festivities themselves are crowded into the few days just before Lent. These happy children are all ready to take part in one of the carnival processions on Guadeloupe.

